

Press Release

For Immediate Release

12th August 1987

Dinosaur Display at Auckland Museum

A world-ranking dinosaur display will open at the Auckland Museum in October, in the most ambitious international exhibition the Museum has yet staged.

Called 'Firth's Dinosaurs in New Zealand', the exhibition brings together dinosaur bones and skeletons from China, Australia, North America, Europe and New Zealand which have never been seen before in this country.

"There are some gigantic replicas of dinosaur skeletons from China," said the Director of the Auckland Museum, Stuart Park. "Mamenchisaurus is 22 metres (66 ft) long from head to tail. When it was fully fleshed, it probably weighed between 40 and 50 tonnes. Another, Tsintaosaurus, stands 5.5 metres (17 ft) high."

Firth's Dinosaurs is a co-operative venture between the Museum of Victoria in Melbourne and the Auckland Museum, with support from the Fletcher Challenge company, Firth Concrete Products. Last year, Fletcher Challenge sponsored the Inca Gold Exhibition at the Museum which attracted a then record 67,000 viewers.

"Much of our latest exhibition is currently on display in Melbourne where it is highly successful and attracting huge crowds," said Mr Park. "It is billed there as the best exhibition you will see in a million years and I'm sure that will apply in New Zealand too."

"Although the scale of the Chinese dinosaur skeletons will be the most awesome aspect of the display, the extent of the Australian dinosaur material will probably surprise," added Mr Park.

"Over the last ten years or so, there have been major discoveries of dinosaur material, in Queensland and Victoria in particular," he said. "The Australian continent was rich in small to medium sized dinosaurs including some that seemed to adapt to quite cold conditions."

New Zealand will be represented by its solitary dinosaur relic - part of a tail bone from what is called the Mangahouanga dinosaur. Found in Hawkes Bay, the vertebra was first scientifically described in 1981. Probably about 4 metres (12 ft) long, 2 metres (6 ft) high and weighing 400 kg, New Zealand's only recognized dinosaur to date is believed to have beachcombed the shoreline 65-70 million years ago living on washed-up, huge shellfish called 'ammonites'.

Bones of New Zealand marine reptiles that lived during the age of the dinosaurs, such as the crocodile-like mosasaur, 15 m (45 ft) long, and the plesiosaur, a snake-necked reptile with an overall body length of about 14 m (42 ft) will also be included in the exhibition.

"Among children especially, dinosaurs have always been a source of fascination so we expect the Firth exhibition will really appeal to families," said Mr Park. "Our staff are currently preparing extensive educational kits for schools as well as revising the excellent Australian catalogue which is a library resource in its own right."

He added that although some of the Firth dinosaur exhibition were replicas for practical and security reasons, there was a substantial amount of original material that had never before been seen outside Australia.

"Visitors will actually be able to handle one massive bone that came from a huge dinosaur from the United States," he said. "That's really getting in touch with the prehistoric past!"

New Zealand's first dinosaur exhibition will appear only in Auckland as it is required back in Australia for a January exhibition in Tasmania. "It is a very complex display that takes quite some time to assemble and set up," said Mr Park. "It is insured for \$500,000 and will cost about half that amount to set up and promote in Auckland, hence our thanks to Firth Concrete Products for enabling it all to happen."

For further information, contact Stuart Park (Director) or Sherry Reynolds (Assistant Director) at Auckland Museum (phone (09) 390-443).